obstructions and other blockages. One test that is non-invasive and has seen a huge technological advancement in accuracy is the CT heart scan. Unlike CT scans for the brain, those for the heart needed more 'slices' to capture the images better. Today, heart CT scans use up to 256 slices to produce an accurate cross-sectional image of the heart compared to the 64 slices used earlier. Hospitals are also equipped with a host of other new testing devices that can pinpoint where the problem lies. These include Echocardiography (real-time monitoring of the heart using high frequency radio waves), Transoesophageal Echocardiography (in which a probe is inserted through the throat to determine blood clots and any blockages), Gamma camera (which uses radiation to determine heart health) and Cardiac Electrophysiology (where a catheter is inserted into the heart muscle to detect abnormalities). To start with, though, doctors recommend good old annual blood assessments. However, those with strong risk factors such as genetics and lifestyle should go for more advanced testing such as CT Angio scans. "These are the highest advancement in early diagnosis for those with high risk factors," says Dr Seth. "They can accurately depict blockages in the heart so that treatment begins early."

THE BIG ADVANCES IN TREATMENT

Be aware of your symptoms to begin with, experts recommend. "If you get any sort of pain that lasts for more than a few minutes, rush to a doctor immediately. Continuous pain is never a good sign. Even if it isn't a heart condition, it could be something else. Mostly, people ignore the smaller symptoms and come in once the condition has aggravated," says Dr Bahl. Many others stay away for fear of confirming what they suspect. "I was feeling extremely weak and finding it difficult to walk long distances," confesses 39-year-old Diya Pawaskar, a homemaker from Pune, who was diagnosed with cardiovascular disease in 2019. "It took me two days before I went to the hospital because I kept hoping the problem would go away. I had this mental fear that once you fall sick with a major condition, your life is over." Instead, Pawaskar has since gone on to travel to Europe, have a second child and survive Covid as well.

Assuaging the fear that all heart treatment is invasive or involves long hospital stays, doctors say this is not the case any more. Unless the condition is severe, stent surgery can successfully

THE DIAGNOSTIC TOOLKIT

TREADMILL TESTS, ECGs AND EEGs ARE NOT THE ONLY DIAGNOSTIC TESTS AVAILABLE TO DETECT HEART ISSUES. THE TECH FOR PRIMARY DIAGNOSIS HAS UNDERGONE A SEA CHANGE. HERE ARE A FEW

BLOOD TESTS

C-reactive protein: An inflammatory protein, higher levels indicate higher risk of cardiac arrest

Plasma ceramides: Their detection has been linked to plaque build-up in the heart and taken to be a sign of blockage



Brain natriuretic peptides: A hormone often secreted to help ease pressure on a heart when it is experiencing problems pumping

Calcium scoring: Helps determine plaque build-up in the heart

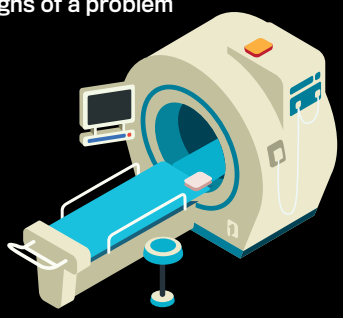
Troponin T: Increased levels of the protein have been linked to increased risk

NON-INVASIVE TESTS

CT heart scan: An advanced CT angio scan can paint a 3D image of the heart in less than a third of a second. This helps show blockages, state of the arteries and other vital parameters of heart health

Echocardiography: Real-time monitoring of the heart using high frequency radio waves remains a crucial diagnostic tool

Experimental handheld devices: From smartphones to retina scanners, these use ECG to track your heart beat and can act as early warning signs of a problem



MINIMALLY INVASIVE TESTS

Transoesophageal Echocardiography: A probe inserted through the throat can detect blood clots or other blockages

Cardiac electrophysiology: A catheter is inserted into the heart muscle to detect any abnormalities

